



Inspiring Excellence

**CST309: Global Citizenship
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**FEASIBLE ACTION PROPOSAL & SDG ANALYSIS:
THE BIHARI COMMUNITY OF BANGLADESH**

Submitted By:

Name: Tahsin Raihan Robbani

Student ID: 22201344

Section: 1

Submitted To:

Sharmistha Ghosh

Assistant Professor

School of General Education

BRAC University

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The Problem

The Bihari community in Geneva Camp, Dhaka, faces severe de facto administrative statelessness. Although the landmark 2008 Bangladesh High Court ruling legally recognized their birthright citizenship (Siddiqi, 2013), community members are systematically denied passports, national NID cards, and formal banking access due to police verification filters flagging their camp address. This structural exclusion directly violates SDG Target 16.9 regarding universal legal identity and SDG Target 10.3 on eliminating discriminatory policies (United Nations, 2015).

Proposed Action

To alleviate this crisis, I propose establishing a "**Camp Youth Administrative Legal & Digital Facilitation Desk**," operated as a collaborative pilot between BRAC University student volunteers, legal aid advocates, and the Stranded Pakistanis Youth Rehabilitation Movement (SPYRM), building on the community led legal advocacy model documented in Bangladesh's Bihari camps. The desk would provide-

1. **Navigating the system:** Volunteers sit with the camp youth and guide them through the online government system for NID applications, birth registration and processing of their passports, thus preventing errors that result in automatic rejection.
2. **Legal backing:** Where police or passport officials reject an application solely on the basis of a camp address, the desk supplies standardized legal letters for demonstrating that such rejections are unlawful.
3. **Digital literacy training:** Residents are equipped with skills to access government e-services on their own and work as freelance or remotely to cut dependency on intermediaries in the long-term.

Feasibility Assessment

- **Legal Feasibility:** Grounded in the binding precedent of *Abid Khan and Others v. Government of Bangladesh* (2003) and Article 31 of the Constitution, requiring no new legislation.
- **Financial Feasibility:** Operates at minimal cost by utilizing existing SPYRM community centers in Geneva Camp and student volunteer paralegals.
- **Operational Feasibility:** Navigates police bureaucracy through standardized documentation packages and university backed institutional advocacy.

Impact Analysis

This campaign breaks the cycle of exclusionary "camp address" filter and empowers Urdu-speaking youth from being passive holders of documents to active citizens. It directly opens doors to formal jobs, legal overseas migration, bank access, university admission and serves Andrew Linklater's Sphere of Cosmopolitan Duty and the state's moral obligation under the Harm Principle to remove institutional suffering (Linklater, 1998).

References

Abid Khan and Others v. Government of Bangladesh and Others, Writ Petition No. 3831 of 2001

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Siddiqi, D. M. (2013). Left behind by the nation: 'Stranded Pakistanis' in Bangladesh. *Sites: New Series*, 10(1), 150–183. <https://doi.org/10.11157/sites-vol10iss2id253>

United Nations. (2015). *Transforming our world: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development* (A/RES/70/1). <https://sdgs.un.org/2030agenda>